The Illusion of the Given

Plain English Exposition, Multi-Dimensional Cosmology, and Parallel Buddhist Traditions

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PART I: THE CORE TEXT IN SIMPLE LAYMAN'S ENGLISH

A Full, Paragraph-by-Paragraph Rendering

Introduction: The Puzzle of Agreement

Whenever different people look at the world and report the same features, our minds instinctively make a big assumption: we assume that this agreement must come from a solid, objective object standing quietly behind what we see. If two humans look at a river, or if a human, a dog, and an ant walk across the same patch of dirt, ordinary common sense insists there must be an underlying physical thing—an objective bedrock—that each creature simply registers or filters through its own biological senses.

In classical Indian and Tibetan philosophy, this puzzle is brought into sharp focus by a famous thought experiment: a single bowl of liquid seen by different kinds of beings.

- To an ordinary human, it appears as refreshing, thirst-quenching water.
- To a hungry ghost (a being consumed by intense habits of craving and lack), it appears as disgusting, burning pus and blood.
- To a fish or aquatic creature, it appears as an ambient atmosphere to breathe and a home to swim in.
- To a god in a celestial realm, it appears as heavenly, ambrosial nectar.
- To an awakened noble being, it appears as the radiant, pure wisdom-energy of water (the female Buddha Māmakī).

The immediate reflex of ordinary realism is to explain this difference through a two-layer, dualistic picture. We naturally imagine that some neutral, uncarved raw stuff (whether described as chemical H_2O molecules, bare matter, or pure physical energy) sits in that exact coordinate space, and that differing organisms merely view that pre-existing substance through their own specialized sensory glasses.

However, both the Middle Way (Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka) and foundational-free Dzogchen (the Great Perfection) reject this assumption completely. When we examine it carefully, the idea of a shared thing that exists all by itself, beneath all the ways it appears,

completely falls apart. Furthermore, this insight has strong echoes—though not proofs—in modern physics and the philosophy of science, specifically Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics and Karen Barad's Agential Realism. These modern scientific views are used here only as helpful illustrations. If we were to turn around and treat relationships as the new "real stuff," we would simply be laying down another floor.

Agreement does not require a hidden bedrock. Orderly patterns do not require an ultimate floor. When conditions change, appearances change—not because different observers decode one untouched thing in different ways, but because the object seen, the observer looking, and the channel through which they interact are all designated together within dependent arising. The relationships between things are just as impossible to find as fixed things themselves.

1. The Trap of the Hidden Substance

When someone says that "different species see the same liquid differently," they slip in an unexamined noun: "the liquid." This claim quietly assumes that before anyone ever encounters it, a finished physical entity already sits there in quiet isolation, waiting to be inspected.

This is the classic retreat into the philosophy made famous by Immanuel Kant, known as transcendental idealism:

- **The Claim:** A hidden "thing-in-itself" exists completely beyond our minds, while living organisms simply stamp their own biological categories, spatial coordinates, and sensory habits onto it.
- **The Middle Way Critique:** If this hidden bedrock really exists prior to and independent of being experienced, what is it actually like? If it has definite properties (such as being refreshing water), it completely fails to explain why the hungry ghost directly encounters burning pus. If it has no properties at all, a featureless, property-free ghost cannot act as a real-world cause to trigger any sensory experience whatsoever.

Kant himself never claimed the thing-in-itself acts as a physical cause inside our everyday experience, though he called it the "non-sensible cause" of appearances—which is precisely where his critics found the logical flaw. And while Middle Way thinkers accept everyday cause and effect as practical convention, the core insight holds firm: a hidden substrate stripped of all relationships can explain nothing at all.

The "Wet-and-Moist" Counter-Argument

A thoughtful person might push back: "Why assume the hidden thing must be water or pus? Why couldn't it simply be 'wetness and moisture'—the basic physical quality common to both?"

This is a natural suggestion. Classical Buddhist psychology identifies wetness and moisture as the defining mark of the water element, common to whatever is fluid. But this suggestion faces a clear fork in the road:

1. **If wetness is claimed as something that exists on its own:** The argument fails. A generic, universal "wetness" is merely an abstract mental concept. In real life, wetness never floats in mid-air; it only ever shows up as this drinkable water, this caustic pus, or this fluid home for a fish. Furthermore, fluidity itself is a relationship: what acts as a fluid to a large biological creature with cell membranes does not function as a fluid to physical systems operating at subatomic scales or under different fundamental forces.
2. **If wetness is treated as an everyday practical reference point:** It is no longer a hidden thing-in-itself. It becomes a perfectly valid working label—a practical convention that lets human debaters compare and discuss different perspectives without pretending to point to an absolute, observer-independent floor.

As Nāgārjuna demonstrated, the real target of critical analysis is *svabhāva*: the belief in an intrinsic nature that exists all by itself, independent of anything else. Positing an uncarved "neutral stuff" beneath appearances is simply that old belief wearing a disguise.

2. Agreement Without a Hidden Substance: The Middle Way Account

If there is no inherently established object behind appearances, why do humans reliably agree that the liquid is water? Why doesn't our shared world collapse into chaos or private fantasy?

In Chapter 6 of his work *Entering the Middle Way*, the Indian master Candrakīrti provides the answer: agreement does not prove there is a hidden substrate beneath things; shared, reliable everyday coherence is the very definition of conventional truth.

A. Mind and Object Depend on Each Other

Candrakīrti spends substantial effort dismantling the "Mind-Only" view, which tries to solve the problem by getting rid of external matter and making an intrinsically real consciousness the sole foundation. Candrakīrti proves that consciousness and physical objects exist in strict mutual dependence:

- A perceiving mind cannot be identified without reference to an object that is perceived.
- An object cannot be identified without reference to the perceptual and conceptual framework that picks it out.

Neither mind nor matter comes first. Making the mind into an ultimate container is just as mistaken as making physical matter into the container.

B. Healthy Senses vs. Impairment Within Each Kind of Being

Candrakīrti distinguishes what the world accepts as true from what even the world recognizes as an error, based on whether a being's senses are healthy or impaired (for example, by an eye disease). Later thinkers called these correct and mistaken conventions. The classic examples are a person with jaundice who sees a white conch shell as yellow, or someone with an eye disease who sees floating hairs in the air.

Crucially, sensory health or impairment is defined strictly within a biological or karmic group:

- A human with jaundice sees the white conch as yellow. Because other humans with healthy eyes see it as white, the jaundiced person is conventionally mistaken by human standards.
- The hungry ghost, however, is not a "jaundiced human." Relative to the hungry ghost's own karmic conditioning, its senses are functioning normally. It is not suffering an optical illusion of water; for it, the liquid genuinely functions as burning pus.

Furthermore, this division into correct and mistaken is made purely from the viewpoint of everyday worldly life. Candrakīrti points out that awakened noble beings, having cleared away fundamental confusion, see compounded things as like reflections in a mirror: for them, these are mere conventions, not absolute truths.

C. A Working Reference Point

To avoid falling into nihilism (the mistaken belief that nothing exists), this analysis draws a clear distinction in line with Tsongkhapa's reading. The hungry ghost's perception of pus is treated as a real conventional perception shaped by karma, not as an optical mistake.

What Is Negated	What Is Conventionally Accepted
An inherently established common base: A mind-independent physical substance possessing its own standalone identity before anyone observes it.	**A mere working reference point:** A dependently designated convergence point where different karmic appearances meet and can be compared.

What prevents this working reference point from sliding back into a hidden "thing-in-itself"?

This working reference point is not a solid carrier of qualities that exists before its relationships. It has no qualities whatsoever apart from those that show up through a specific channel of contact. It is simply a practical label made from within an everyday frame—usually our human frame—which allows us to coordinate and compare different viewpoints. Its job is to coordinate perspectives, not to sit underneath them. It serves the same function in the Middle Way as cross-perspective links do in relational quantum mechanics, rather than acting like a classical physical substance.

D. Where the Bowl Example Came From: Vasubandhu and Candrakīrti's Reply

The bowl example did not originate in the Middle Way. In his *Twenty Verses*, the philosopher Vasubandhu used the hungry ghosts to defend the Mind-Only school. Critics asked: if there are no external objects, why do our perceptions agree? Why do many people see the exact same thing at the same time and place? Vasubandhu answered that just as hungry ghosts with identical karma all see a river of pus together, shared karma ripening within consciousness accounts for shared perception. No river outside the mind is required.

That answers our core question by making consciousness the ultimate floor. Candrakīrti completely turns this example around. He takes the hungry ghost seeing pus, compares it to someone with an eye disease, and concludes that just as the external object does not exist on its own, neither does the mind. If the pus has no independent reality because it is not an external thing-in-itself, the mind seeing the pus has no independent reality either, because mind and object arise together. For the hungry ghost, the river of pus and the perception of pus stand or fall together. In everyday worldly terms, both mind and object are accepted; under ultimate analysis, neither can be found existing on its own. So the bowl does not prove that the world exists inside the mind. It proves that neither the world nor the mind is an ultimate floor. Shared karma explains why beings agree, but karma is simply one condition among many, not an absolute mental storehouse.

3. Other Observers

Agreement naturally requires other observers to agree with. This brings up three important questions: how we know other observers exist, whether this explanation is circular, and what role language plays.

A. Other Minds

Shared experience assumes there are other observers whose experiences could match mine. How do we know they exist? Indian Buddhist philosophers debated this extensively. Dharmakīrti argued that we infer other minds: other bodies move and speak with purpose just as mine does when I have an intention, so we infer their mental streams from their actions. Later, Ratnakīrti, arguing from the Mind-Only view, claimed that other minds can never finally be proven.

Both thinkers shared an assumption rejected here: that my own private mind is immediately given and certain, while other minds are merely inferred or doubtful. The Middle Way refuses this asymmetry. When analyzed, my own stream of consciousness is no more findable as an independent entity than yours is; both are designated in dependence on changing physical and mental parts, and both function perfectly in daily life. The certainty I feel about "my" experience and the doubt I feel about "yours" are just the old habit of reification turned inward, making the private self into the one unquestioned floor. In everyday life, the world accepts other minds just as naturally as it accepts tables. Other

observers are not a conclusion deduced from a private starting point; they are designated together with oneself, just as "long" is designated alongside "short."

B. Is Agreement Circular?

A critic might ask: faculties are considered healthy when they agree with other members of their group, and the group is defined by sharing those very faculties. The standards define the group, and the group defines the standards. Isn't that circular?

It is circular, and that circle is not a flaw. Circularity would be fatal only if agreement were required to rest on an outside foundation—an ultimate, non-participating judge. The Middle Way denies that any such judge exists. Our ways of knowing and the things known are established only in relation to one another. Because nothing is being built from an absolute ground up, there is no missing foundation for the circle to lack. Ludwig Wittgenstein reached a similar conclusion from another direction: what makes following a rule possible is agreement not in private opinions, but in a shared "form of life"; language requires agreement not just in dictionary definitions, but in everyday judgments. Agreement is not proof of an unmoving object behind the scenes; it is simply convention at work. This circle does not make errors impossible: inside our everyday framework, mistakes are easily corrected—a jaundiced eye is corrected by healthy companions, and a misreading is corrected by a second look. What the circle rules out is an impossible correction from outside every perspective.

C. Language

For human beings, the framework that keeps track of agreement is, above all, language. Words and labels are learned from others, corrected by others, and shared with others. A child learns "water" as a word that works: say the word, and a glass is brought. That is why humans agree so precisely not only that liquid is present, but that it is water, that it is cold, and that it is the same water as yesterday's. Labeling goes beyond spoken language: animals coordinate their worlds through perception and physical response without words. But human language carries our circle of agreement across vast distances and generations. It is also where the habit of creating solid entities is strongest: the noun "the bowl" tricks us into imagining an unchanging object standing behind every perspective. The very tool that coordinates our everyday worlds tempts us to believe it describes a single, hidden universe behind them.

4. The Experiential Shift: Non-Foundational Dzogchen

While the Middle Way uses sharp logical reasoning to dismantle rigid metaphysical beliefs, the Great Perfection (Dzogchen) describes how reality is directly met in living experience.

A. The Basis Is Not an Ontological Substrate

In the non-foundational Dzogchen teachings articulated by Longchenpa and Ju Mipham Rinpoche, the primordial basis is carefully distinguished from the karmic storehouse consciousness (*ālaya*):

- The basis is described through three inseparable aspects: its essence, which is empty (primordial purity); its natural clarity, which is spontaneous presence appearing unobstructed; and compassion. We focus here on the first two.
- Primordial purity means that the basis has no solid, independent existence whatsoever. It is not an uncarved lump of cosmic stuff, a universal mind, or an ultimate starting point. Longchenpa explains that the basis is called a "ground" only from a conventional standpoint; in the actual nature of things, it is completely free from being a foundational floor.

B. Self-Display: Ordinary Mind vs. Pure Awareness

Appearances are described as "display" or "self-display." This word "display" must never be understood as the display of some hidden thing standing behind it. It simply means dependent arising itself: vivid, unobstructed, with nothing hidden beneath.

To prevent this from sliding into mentalism (the belief that everything is merely in the mind), Dzogchen draws a clear line between ordinary dualistic mind and pure awareness (*rigpa*):

- **The Grasping Subject Is Part of the Display:** Ordinary dualistic consciousness—the feeling of being an inside subject looking out at an external world—is itself an appearance. It arises symmetrically alongside the external object. Neither mind nor matter creates the other; both arise together within the display.
- **Awareness Is Not a Projector:** Pure awareness (*rigpa*) is not one half of this subject-object split, nor is it a subtle mental substance projecting outward forms. It is simply the immediate knowing of the basis: recognizing that whatever appears is fluid, dependent, and empty. The clarity of appearances belongs to the appearances themselves, not to a separate knower, and like the appearances, it is completely empty.
- **Display Is Not Causal Production:** The basis does not generate appearances the way a physical factory produces goods. Spontaneous presence is not an uncaused motor churning out conditioned things. Appearing is already complete as it is, owing its existence to nothing hidden, and it is empty from the very instant it appears.

C. Reflexive Awareness: A Deliberate Choice

Here the Buddhist traditions face a famous philosophical divide. In *Entering the Middle Way*, Candrakīrti rejected reflexive self-awareness (the idea that consciousness knows itself), using the classic metaphor that a sword cannot cut its own blade. Following Candrakīrti, Tsongkhapa rejected reflexive self-awareness even as a conventional description.

On this point, this analysis follows Ju Mipham Rinpoche:

- **Ultimately:** Mipham fully affirms the Middle Way critique. Under ultimate logical analysis, no self-knowing awareness that exists on its own can ever be found.
- **Conventionally:** Mipham defends reflexive awareness as a practical everyday term to explain memory and immediate experience without requiring an infinite chain of minds watching minds. This is not the truly existing self-awareness that Candrakīrti refuted; it is merely an everyday convention, and empty like every other convention.

In Dzogchen, the self-knowing of awareness is not a real subject knowing itself as an object. It is simply the natural absence of delusion: the immediate, unconstructed clarity of recognizing appearance as an empty display belonging to no one.

D. Mipham's Fourfold Epistemology and Pure Vision

Mipham organizes valid knowing into a fourfold framework:

1. **Impure Conventional Valid Knowing:** Operates within everyday karmic experience. Celestial beings belong here: their experience of liquid as nectar is an elevated karmic perception, not awakened vision.
2. **Pure Conventional Valid Knowing:** Belongs to awakened noble beings, where the liquid appears directly as its pure wisdom nature: Māmakī, the female Buddha of water.
3. **Conceptual Ultimate Valid Knowing:** The intellectual understanding of emptiness reached through rational deduction.
4. **Non-Conceptual Ultimate Valid Knowing:** The direct, living realization of the inseparable unity of primordial purity and spontaneous presence.

How does this fit with Candrakīrti's horizontal relativity? Mipham holds both together. Within ordinary, unawakened perception, validity is strictly relative to each kind of being: the hungry ghost's perception of pus is normal by hungry-ghost standards, and the human's water is normal by human standards. Neither has the final word over the other within everyday life. But between ordinary perception and awakened vision, there is a clear qualitative difference: pure vision is where how things appear matches how things actually are.

Does pure vision bring back a hidden foundation? No. Pure vision is itself completely empty—the inseparable union of appearance and emptiness. It is experience free from dualistic confusion and grasping; it is not a peek behind the curtain at a metaphysical bedrock. Māmakī herself has no inherent existence. Pure vision is accurate not because it finds an ultimate object, but because it meets appearances without the distorting habit that chops reality into separate subjects and solid, external things.

5. Echoes in Modern Physics: Rovelli and Barad

This dismantling of a hidden bedrock without falling into idealism has striking echoes in contemporary physics and philosophy. They are resonances, not proofs. Emptiness does not depend on physics, and scientific models are themselves practical designations—among the most reliable we possess within their fields.

Karen Barad's Agential Realism

- **No Things Before Relationships:** Traditional metaphysics presumes that independent objects exist first and then interact. In agential realism, the things interacting do not exist prior to their "intra-action"; they emerge through it.
- **The Measurement Cut:** Boundaries and physical properties are enacted by specific measuring setups. The measurement cut does not slice up a reality that was already there; it defines what counts as the observer and what counts as the observed in that specific situation.

There is no "liquid" standing there before the measurement cut. The human drinker and the water emerge together within the human biological encounter; the suffering hungry ghost and the pus emerge together within the ghost's karmic encounter.

Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics

In Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics, physical variables do not have absolute values on their own; they take values only relative to another physical system during an interaction.

When critics asked why two observers agree when they compare notes if all values are relative, Emily Adlam and Carlo Rovelli introduced the Cross-Perspective Links postulate: if observer A measures a system and registers a value, and observer B later interacts with both the system and observer A, observer B's measurement will match observer A's record. Agreement between two observers does not require a hidden, unmeasured classical state to have existed beforehand. Agreement is established through physical interaction channels between the observers themselves. Shared reality is produced through relational coordination and cross-checking—the exact counterpart to Candrakīrti's healthy senses confirming one another—not by anchoring to an absolute substrate.

> ***A Critical Caution:*** *Neither quantum mechanics nor agential realism should be read as claiming that "relations" are what really exists. Making the relationship into a new primary substance repeats the very foundationalism it sought to overcome. As Nāgārjuna showed, relationships and the things related arise together; neither comes first, and neither is an absolute floor.*

6. Different Channels of Contact

If an appearance requires specific senses, conditions, and interaction channels, what happens when a being encounters an environment with which it shares little or no contact?

The answer is neither "absolutely nothing" (which would make reality private and erase everyday cause and effect) nor a hidden classical object (which would bring back an absolute floor). Contact comes in degrees, and what holds true for any system depends entirely on which physical and cognitive channels are active.

A. Jakob von Uexküll's Tick

In biology, Jakob von Uexküll showed that an animal does not inhabit an abstract, neutral environment, but an *Umwelt*—a functional world carved out by its own sensory-effector loops:

- The common tick responds primarily to three signals: the smell of mammal sweat (butyric acid), the warmth of a living body, and hair.
- A pool of clear spring water has none of these signals, so it does not exist within the tick's perceptual world.

Yet the water is not "nothing" to the tick: the tick can still drown in it. The tick is uncoupled from the optical and perceptual channels of the water, but it remains fully coupled to its surface tension and fluid dynamics. This demonstrates why conventional reality is not trapped inside a private mind: cause and effect operate along specific relational channels whether an organism is consciously aware of them or not.

B. Different Channels in Physics

- **Dark Matter:** As far as modern observations show, dark matter does not interact with light or electromagnetism, so it passes right through the Earth without collision. To an electromagnetic sensor, the Earth is a solid wall; to dark matter, that wall does not exist. Yet it remains coupled through gravity: the Earth's mass bends its path.
- **Neutrinos:** A solar neutrino passes through vast distances of solid lead with almost no chance of hitting an atom. The lead is neither a solid wall nor pure nothingness; it is an area of extremely weak coupling.

C. Classical Buddhist Accounts

This spectrum of relational coupling makes sense of traditional Buddhist accounts without needing a hidden substrate:

- **Spirits Passing Through Mountains:** Spirits whose subtle bodies have no coarse physical density pass effortlessly through solid stone. Solidity is not an intrinsic property of rock; it is a resistance actualized only when two systems of similar physical density collide.

- **The Formless Realms:** Beings in deep formless meditative absorption have turned off coarse sensory organs; physical objects simply do not function relative to their cognitive frame.

The bowl of liquid remains a practical reference point. It is not erased just because an uncoupled observer fails to see it. But what appears there—a solid barrier, refreshing drink, burning pus, or open space—depends entirely on the channels enacted in the meeting.

D. Across Realms: The Water Offering

The hardest test of this view is interaction between different worlds, which Buddhist practice takes for granted. In traditional water offerings to hungry ghosts, water is blessed with a mantra and offered, and tradition holds that it reaches them as soothing nectar. If each realm arises within its own karmic perception, how can an action in one realm reach another?

Not by a physical substance traveling between worlds. Nothing travels from the human bowl into the hungry ghost's mouth, just as the flame at dusk does not physically travel into the flame at midnight. The giving is designated in the human world (water, a mantra, a generous intention); the relief is designated in the hungry ghost's world (nectar instead of pus). The two are connected through dependent arising—as a condition in one frame and a result in another. This has the exact structure of cross-perspective links: connection across viewpoints without any hidden substance beneath.

7. The Myth of the Container

Why do we cling so stubbornly to the idea of a hidden object? The root obstacle is the "Container Myth"—the classical intuition of absolute space and time:

1. We imagine space as an empty, ready-made three-dimensional box.
2. We imagine placing a solid object in the center of the box.
3. We place observers inside the box and assume they must either see the real object or suffer an illusion.

Both modern physics and the Middle Way dismantle this box completely:

- **Modern Physics:** In Einstein's General Relativity, spacetime is not an empty box; it is the gravitational field itself—a physical fabric that interacts with matter and energy. In quantum gravity, space itself is composed of relational networks.
- **The Middle Way:** In Chapter 5 of the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, Nāgārjuna shows that space cannot exist prior to its defining characteristics (such as the absence of obstruction). Space and the objects within it are designated together.

When space ceases to be an absolute warehouse, the puzzle of how an object can appear differently across species completely dissolves. Space, time, observer, and observed are all designated together, and none of them is the container of the rest.

8. Why Is There Order at All?

This brings us to the final question realism asks: "If there is no ultimate, objective ground, why is there an orderly, reliable web of cause and effect at all? Why don't things dissolve into complete chaos?"

A. The Everyday Answer: Dependent Regularity

The Middle Way does not leave order unexplained. Regularity is accounted for by the lawful nature of dependent origination:

- Causes produce matching effects: barley seeds grow barley, not rice; fire burns and does not freeze.
- Among living beings, shared karma and shared biology shape how appearances unfold.

Everyday reality has its own robust validity. Being empty of independent existence does not make it chaotic or lawless. Emptiness does not cancel cause and effect, nor is emptiness an engine that makes cause and effect work. Things never needed an intrinsic essence in order to function, and something that had an unchangeable essence of its own could never change, grow, or act.

B. Dismantling the Question

When pressed further—"Yes, but why is there an entire web of causes at all?"—the question makes a subtle mistake. It treats the entire web of dependent arising as if it were a single, bounded thing requiring an outside cause.

1. **"The Whole Web" Is a Concept:** A totality does not exist as an independent entity standing alongside its parts. Asking for an outside ground for "everything" is seeking an impossible foundation outside of all relationships.
2. **No First Beginning:** If you invent an ultimate first cause to explain the web, that cause must either depend on a prior cause (continuing the chain endlessly) or have no causes at all (in which case, having no relationships, it could never produce anything). Nāgārjuna shows that dependent arising is beginningless. An endless series is a problem only if you are anxiously seeking a final foundation. Once you stop demanding an absolute floor, having no first beginning is simply what dependent arising looks like.

Conclusion: Working Without a Foundation

Recognizing that similar beings see a similar world because they share similar conditions—and not because of a mind-independent physical bedrock—is neither nihilism nor private fantasy. It does not collapse into idealism, because the mind is just as dependent and empty as the objects it perceives. It does not collapse into lawlessness, because everyday truth

functions with checkable regularity along shared channels of contact. What is eliminated is solely the anxious demand for an absolute foundation.

This insight carries profound consequences for compassion. If the hungry ghost's pus is genuinely pus for the hungry ghost, its suffering is not a mere optical illusion to be dismissed from our human vantage point. No single perspective owns the "real world," so no being's lived experience can be brushed aside. This is why compassion makes complete sense without a fixed self: other beings' worlds are just as real for them as ours is for us, and emptiness takes nothing away from their suffering or from our wish to relieve it.

As Nāgārjuna declared in verse 24.14 of his Middle Way treatise: *"For whom emptiness works, everything works."* And in living experience, when appearances are recognized as unobstructed display without an inside subject grasping an outside object, reality is met as it always was: vivid, unproduced, and never requiring an absolute foundation.

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PART II: THE CONVENTIONAL MULTI-DIMENSIONAL COSMOLOGY

A "Many-Worlds" View Without Metaphysical Realism

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1. Beyond Everett: Parallel Dimensions Without an Absolute Hilbert Space

In contemporary theoretical physics, the Many-Worlds Interpretation (MWI) proposed by Hugh Everett III attempts to resolve quantum measurement puzzles by asserting that all possible outcomes of a quantum event physically occur across a constantly branching multiverse. While this bold hypothesis dismantles classical single-history determinism, it remains firmly anchored to an unyielding metaphysical foundation: an ontologically real, observer-independent Universal Wavefunction evolving within an absolute Hilbert space.

By contrast, the Middle Way and relational Dzogchen framework outlined in Part I allows us to construct a robust, conventional multi-dimensional cosmology that achieves the rich plurality of "many worlds" without positing any metaphysical floor whatsoever. Instead of requiring new physical universes to split off into an unseen cosmic warehouse, multiple fully functional operational dimensions co-exist simultaneously in the exact same location. They do not compete for physical territory, because space itself is not an empty container, but a dependently arisen relationship.

2. The Architecture of Co-Present Dimensions

How can multiple worlds occupy the identical coordinate space without colliding or crowding each other out? The answer lies in the principle of *differential relational coupling*.

- **Dimensions Defined by Channels, Not Spatial Distance:** A "dimension" or "world" is not separated from another by millions of light-years. Rather, a world is the complete network of operational affordances enacted when a specific class of perceptual and physical faculties couples with its environment.
- **The Co-Presence of Realities:** In the exact spot where a human interacts with a flowing freshwater stream, a fish inhabits its atmospheric home, an aquatic microorganism interacts with chemical gradients, a hungry ghost encounters burning fluid, and an awakened noble being meets primordial wisdom-energy. None of these worlds displaces the others. They pass through each other with complete non-obstruction because they do not share the coarse sensory-effector channels that generate physical resistance.
- **No Master Vantage Point:** Conventional multi-dimensionality decisively overthrows human provincialism. Realism tempts humans to believe that our three-dimensional, macroscopic sensory map represents the "base reality" of the universe, while other organisms merely register diminished or altered versions of our world. In a relational cosmology, the human world is simply one conventional slice among countless others—robust and coherent within its own coupling parameters, but possessing zero ontological priority over the worlds of other beings.

3. Relational Bridges Across Dimensions

Unlike Everettian quantum branches, which are fundamentally isolated and causally severed after decoherence, conventional dimensions in this framework can influence and touch one another. However, this interaction does not take place through a physical substance traveling between worlds, but through *dependent conditions and cross-perspective links*.

When an act of deliberate generosity or meditative focus is performed in the human realm (such as the traditional water blessing offering discussed in Part I), it serves as a transformative condition. In the human frame, it is enacted as water and intentional compassion; in the hungry ghost's frame, it ripens as cooling nectar. The two dimensions meet not through a physical pipeline, but through the seamless, non-local web of dependent origination. Compassion functions as a genuine cross-dimensional bridge precisely because neither realm is locked into a rigid, inherently existent material shell.

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PART III: CLASSICAL BUDDHIST TRADITIONS ARTICULATING THE MULTI-DIMENSIONAL VIEW

Huayan, Tiantai, Yogācāra, and Vajrayāna Resonances

1. The Huayan Tradition: The Non-Obstruction of Phenomena (Shi-Shi Wu-Ai)

The most philosophically sophisticated and celebrated articulation of this multi-dimensional vision in East Asian Buddhism is found in the Huayan school, formulated by masters such as Tu-shun and Fazang based on the *Avataṃsaka Sūtra* (Flower Ornament Scripture). Huayan directly dismantled the Container Myth centuries before modern physics through its doctrine of the Four Dharmadhātus (Four Realms of Reality):

1. **Shi Dharmadhātu:** The realm of distinct, individual everyday phenomena.
2. **Li Dharmadhātu:** The realm of ultimate principle or emptiness (*śūnyatā*).
3. **Li-Shi Wu-Ai:** The non-obstruction between ultimate principle and everyday phenomena—form is emptiness and emptiness is form.
4. **Shi-Shi Wu-Ai (事事無礙):** The mutual interpenetration and complete non-obstruction between phenomena themselves.

In ordinary physical thinking, two solid objects cannot occupy the same location because they push each other away. Huayan demonstrates that because all phenomena are entirely empty of an independent self-nature (*svabhāva*), **phenomena do not obstruct one another**. A single microscopic dust mote contains infinite Buddha-realms, and countless cosmic dimensions occupy the exact same spot without expanding the boundary of the space or crowding one another. This is immortalized in the image of *Indra's Net*, where infinite multi-faceted jewels reflect one another endlessly without any single jewel acting as the foundational floor.

2. Tiantai: The Mutual Containment of the Ten Realms (Shi Jie Hu Ju)

The Tiantai tradition, founded by the great master Zhiyi, develops this co-presence into an explicit phenomenology of living dimensions known as the *Mutual Inclusion of the Ten Realms* (*Shi Jie Hu Ju*, 十界互具) and the doctrine of *Three Thousand Realms in a Single Thought-Moment* (*Yi Nian San Qian*, 一念三千).

Tiantai teaches that each of the Ten Realms of sentient existence—ranging from the hell beings and hungry ghosts up through animals, humans, devas, to Bodhisattvas and fully awakened Buddhas—inherently contains and permeates all other nine realms. These worlds are not physically stacked above and below each other like floors in an apartment building. Instead, all three thousand facets of existence are completely co-present within any single

experiential moment. A human environment, a hellish environment, and a celestial pure land exist in the exact same spatial locus. Which dimension is experienced depends entirely on the operational mode of affective grasping, habit, and intentional action (karma).

3. Yogācāra: Collective Karma as Shared Dimensional Framing (Sādhāraṇa-Karma)

While Yogācāra is frequently labeled as subjective idealism, its technical explanations of cosmological realms in works like Vasubandhu's *Abhidharmakośa* and *Viṃśatikā* provide a rigorous relational account of dimensional partitioning:

- **Worlds Formed by Shared Ripening:** A "world" (*loka*) is not a pre-existing physical box of rock and air; it is the collective ripening (*vipāka*) of shared karmic impressions (*sādhāraṇa-karma*).
- **Dimensional Separation Without Physical Walls:** Because humans share similar cognitive and physical karmic traces, they converge upon a shared operational container world (*bhājana-loka*). Hungry ghosts share a different karmic legacy and therefore inhabit a completely distinct operational dimension right alongside humans. They do not collide with human buildings or people because their perceptual and bodily channels do not cross at the coarse physical level.

4. Vajrayāna Tantra: The Co-Presence of Samsara and the Pure Mandala (Dag-snang)

In Tibetan Vajrayāna, the bowl-of-liquid thought experiment is transformed into the primary engine of spiritual realization through the doctrine of *Pure Vision* (*dag-snang*):

- **The Pure Land Is Not Elsewhere:** Vajrayāna explicitly rejects the idea that Pure Lands or divine mandalas are distant planets located millions of miles away in outer space. The sacred mandala of the enlightened deity and the mundane, confused world of Samsara occupy the exact same coordinate space right now.
- **A Shift in Channel, Not a Shift in Geography:** When an advanced practitioner attains pure vision, the coarse physical room does not explode or vanish; rather, because adventitious cognitive obscurations are cleared away, the environment is directly recognized as the celestial palace of the deity, and the coarse elements are recognized as the wisdom-energies of the female Buddhas (such as water recognized as Māmakī). The mundane world and the awakened world are completely co-dimensional; what shifts is strictly the relational mode of perception and realization.

5. Non-Foundational Dzogchen: Transparent Non-Obstruction (Zang-thal)

In the Great Perfection (Dzogchen) teachings of Longchenpa and Ju Mipham, this multi-dimensional reality is characterized as *zang-thal*—all-penetrating, unimpeded, and completely transparent openness. Because every appearance is the natural radiance (*rtsal*) of primordial purity (*ka-dag*), appearances possess no solid core whatsoever that could displace or collide with another appearance. An infinite array of karmic displays can arise simultaneously within the primordially pure basis without crowding it, because the basis is not an extended physical warehouse—it is completely empty.

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Comparative Summary: Quantum Multiverse vs. Buddhist Relational Worlds

To bring the entire synthesis into clear focus, the following comparison highlights how this Buddhist multi-dimensional framework differs profoundly from Everett's Many-Worlds Interpretation in physics:

Dimension / Aspect	Everett's Quantum Many-Worlds (MWI)	Buddhist Relational Cosmology (Huayan / Dzogchen)
Underlying Substrate	Requires an absolute, mind-independent mathematical entity: the *Universal Wavefunction* evolving in Hilbert space.	**Rejects all substrates.** There is no hidden wavefunction, physical floor, or cosmic mind beneath appearances.
Nature of Parallel Worlds	Physical timelines continuously splitting through decoherence into physically separated branches.	**Co-present dependent arisings.** Multiple worlds exist in the exact same spot, separated only by differing sensory and karmic coupling.
Spatial Framework	Retains the container concept by embedding branches in an absolute mathematical Hilbert coordinate space.	**Dismantles the Container Myth.** Space is not an empty box; space and objects are designated together.
Cross-Realm Interaction	Parallel branches are causally disconnected; observers in different branches cannot interact.	Realms do not physically collide, yet can interact relationally through dependent arising and cross-perspective links (e.g. offerings).
Status of Observers	Observers are physical systems splitting mechanically along quantum branches.	Observers and observed environments co-emerge dependently; neither enjoys ontological priority.

By dispensing with the demand for an ultimate metaphysical bedrock, both Buddhist philosophy and relational science show that reality is naturally open, vibrant, and multi-dimensional. Multiple worlds co-exist without friction, effortlessly sharing the same space because none of them possesses an unbending, solid essence to push the others away.